I called Sarabhai who sounded impressed. ‘You eye liquid stuff anywhere you go,’ he said, ‘and now you have got something too.’

I hated the British rulers of India, especially Robert Clive who was instrumental in the East India Company’s systemic exploitation of India. I asked Cleaver if he could tell me where Clive’s resting place was. Cleaver asked around his colleagues, but none of them knew. Later, we discovered Clive’s tomb at Moreton Say, near his birthplace of Shropshire. It was a non-descript resting place for a man who established the British crown’s military and political supremacy over India. Call it puerile or profound, I felt a strange sense of satisfaction standing there.

In less than twenty-four hours, I would stand frozen in disbelief and uncertainty, as the BBC flashed the news of Vikram Sarabhai’s death.

ISRO deputed Ratnaraj Jayamani, who later became the first project director of GSLV, to bring home the Rolls Royce hydraulics lab from Spadeadam. He did a meticulous job getting people to disassemble the hardware and pack them. However, when one of the packs reached the airport, it was found to be too big to get through the mouth of the cargo hold. After a few weeks, a cargo aircraft carrying what was once a hydraulics lab flew to Trivandrum. It was only then we realised that we don’t have a place to set up the lab. We emptied two of the three ISRO apartments in Veli Hills in Trivandrum, and converted them into a godown for the precious consignment. As the two apartments could not take them in full, some of the gadgets and parts were kept in a basement of the security building. Cleaver would turn in his grave if he knew what happened to them.

The heap of tubes and gadgets, which once formed an enviable laboratory in Spadeadam, was systematically plundered by our scientists who took them away for experiments. As the custodian of the consignment, I made some attempts to get a piece of land to set up the laboratory, but wasn’t successful. So, here came scientists, one asking for a recorder, another taking away a pressure sensor, a third one snatching a flow meter. After giving up on setting up the facility on a new campus, I silently let these go, in a heartrending way, that it was probably better at least some of